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Joachim of Fiore and the Influence of Inspiration

Essays in Memory of Marjorie E. Reeves (1905–2003)

Edited by

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Preface

The essays which follow here are offered in gratitude both to honour the memory of Marjorie E. Reeves (1905–2003) and as a modest tribute to her distinguished lifelong career as scholar and teacher. Although an active contributor to so many fields, much of her research and a great deal of her personal affection were devoted to the life and work of the Calabrian abbot Joachim of Fiore (d. 1202). Indeed, it was our mutual quest for Joachim which initiated a treasured long-distance correspondence between us, eventually culminating in several invitations to Oxford.

On the eve of what was to be my last visit to that famous house in Norham Gardens, I watched with friends a video which Marjorie had made in 1988 in the series *Interviews with Historians*, commissioned by the Institute of Historical Research in London. From her interview with Gillian Lewis, I was surprised to learn that she would soon be celebrating her centenary – news which seemed hard to believe. Although frail, she was full of energy, quick to laugh and talk in spirited fashion, with a vivid interest in her visitors and, as always, she insisted on preparing tea for us, which we drank in her room with its book-lined walls, looking out over her beloved springtime garden. The frontispiece photograph in this volume was taken on this same April afternoon when Marjorie was a mere 97 years old. Not many days later, we ventured to dream of a Centenary volume on Joachim of Fiore to which all Joachites, young and old, could contribute, not only those who had benefited from Marjorie Reeves's scholarly achievements but others, too, who had profited from her generous teaching, advice, and encouragement. And wonderful to relate, scholars from many countries, from across several generations, friends and disciples of both Marjorie Reeves and Joachim from Fiore, gathered together and consented to write the essays for this volume.

In her long 'pilgrimage' with Abbot Joachim,¹ as she herself called it, Marjorie Reeves first discovered, then published, and shared much new and exciting evidence on Joachim of Fiore. She it was who originally compiled a list of Joachim's *opera*, the authentic and the pseudo-epigraphic,² collating and

¹ Marjorie E. Reeves, 'A Sixty-year Pilgrimage with the Abbot Joachim', *Florentia. Bollettino del Centro internazionale di Studi Gioachimiti*, 6 (1992), 7–32.

² Marjorie E. Reeves, *The Influence of Prophecy in the Later Middle Ages: A Study in Joachimism* (Oxford, 1969, repr. London, 1993), 511–35.

Chapter 4

Joachim of Fiore as Political Thinker

Matthias Riedl

The Middle Ages and the Concept of 'the Political'

According to Marjorie Reeves, Joachim of Fiore was not a political thinker. If in the following pages I attempt to show that political reflection is not at the periphery but at the centre of Joachim's thought, this is not to dispute the results of Marjorie Reeves's research. I only wish to suggest that it may be possible to use the concept of 'the political' in another way.

Like many historians, Marjorie Reeves applied the concept of the political almost exclusively to secular powers while she spoke of the church as the sphere of religion. Consequently, she described Joachim of Fiore primarily as a religious thinker whose prophecies have some political implications insofar as they predict the collapse of all worldly power. She describes the abbot's vision of the third *status* as purely religious because it depicts a Christian society organized as the monastic *ecclesia spiritualis* – a purified church which will emerge after the decline of all worldly kingdoms, beyond the political stages of history.¹ From this perspective, prophecies that refer to Joachim of Fiore and include the dimension of worldly power in their vision of the final stage of history would appear to be an abuse of the abbot's teachings for political purposes.²

In her studies *The Influence of Prophecy in the Later Middle Ages* and *Joachim of Fiore and the Prophetic Future*, which remain the standard works on Joachimism

¹ 'Politically, Joachim's expectation for the future struck a deterministic note. [...] The Roman Empire had been ordained to hold back barbarian hordes, but when God's Sixth Angel poured his phial on the Euphrates (i.e. the Roman Empire), it would collapse, an event already foreshadowed in the disaster of Frederick Barbarossa and his crusade army in 1187. There was no future political order in Joachim's Sabbath Age: significantly, when he used the symbol of David's triumphal assumption of power in Jerusalem, it was together with the papacy that he placed him in concord. [...] There was to be no salvation through political agencies.' Marjorie Reeves, *Joachim of Fiore and the Prophetic Future* (London, 1976, 2nd rev. edn Stroud, Gloucestershire, 1999), 59.

² 'Political hopes and rivalries soon entered eschatological history. The temptation to allot the roles of worst tyrant and most glorious emperor was irresistible. Thus when, about the middle of the thirteenth century, Joachites began to realize the implications of Joachim's third *status*, they immediately sought to apply these politically. In contrast to the Abbot's own works, the pseudo-Joachimist writings are full of political prophecy.' Marjorie Reeves, *The Influence of Prophecy in the Later Middle Ages: A Study in Joachimism* (Oxford, 1969, repr. Notre Dame, 1993), 306.

to date, Reeves recounts the fate of Joachim's teachings in the centuries after his death. She identifies two traditions of prophetic thought, both of which used and transformed Joachim's predictions. The tradition of 'political Joachimism' emerged among Swabian supporters of Frederick II and the Ghibellines who hoped for the *renovatio* of the German Empire by the Hohenstaufen dynasty; it combines ancient prophecies of the Last Emperor with Joachim's expectation of a peaceful universal society in the last stage of history.³ As Reeves showed, this tradition continued in the later Middle Ages and was used to justify the new forms of national rulership, first of all in France. On the other hand, Reeves observed a tradition of religious prophecy which predicted a spiritual reformation of the institutions of the church or even a spiritual revolution, bringing about an Angelic Pope. This 'spiritual Joachimism', which seems to have its first social basis in the movement of the Spiritual Franciscans, has, according to Marjorie Reeves, a greater right to refer to the works of Joachim of Fiore.⁴

It is not my intention to refute these results and I also agree in its essentials with Reeves's differentiation between a 'papal' and an 'imperial' tradition of Joachimism; I only suggest that we should call both of these traditions political. Eric Voegelin has shown that the modern use of the concepts of 'the religious' and 'the political' is the result of the emancipation of the nation-state from the *sacrum imperium* and implies more or less the institutional separation of church and state.⁵ Therefore the concepts cannot be applied to the high Middle Ages without appearing anachronistic. The restriction of applying the concept of the political to the sphere of the 'state' neglects the fact that in the Middle Ages the world was seen

³ 'Here for the first time we meet Joachim's third *status* recast in political terms, with the second great luminary of the world substituted for the papacy in the work of renewal. So the two streams – of Joachimism and of the ancient World Emperor tradition – meet in this political programme to bring in the seventh age.' Reeves, *Joachim of Fiore*, 62; cf. ead., *Influence*, 311.

⁴ Reeves, *Joachim of Fiore*, 72–82; ead., *Influence*, 393–508.

⁵ 'The state and secular spirit conquered their spheres of power in the fierce battle against the Romano-German Empire of the Middle Ages, and in the course of this struggle linguistic symbols developed, which do not reflect reality as such but which seek to capture and defend the opposite positions of the struggle. The concepts of religion and politics followed the institutions and their symbols: They entered the battlefield and placed themselves under the authority of the linguistic symbols used in the struggle. For this reason, cognition today still involves the contrasts formed under the pressure of their conceptual instruments, although a critical look might reveal merely different examples of the effectiveness of closely related fundamental human forces. The currently prevalent concepts of religion and state in general European usage as well as in a more limited research-based usage are oriented towards certain models whose significance can be traced back to the intellectual struggles waged in Europe. By religion one understands such phenomena as Christianity and the great redemptive religions; by state one means the political organizations of the type of the modern nation-state.' Eric Voegelin, 'The Political Religions', in *The Collected Works of Eric Voegelin*, vol. 5 (Columbia, NY, and London, 2000), 19–73, at 27–8.

as a 'compact and massive unity of the religious and the political'.⁶ The primary symbols by which Western medieval society articulates its self-understanding, *ecclesia* as the *corpus Christi*, and, since the eleventh century, *christianitas* or *societas Christiana*, include the temporal powers as well as the church hierarchy.⁷

In the case of the investiture controversy, for example, in which the Hohenstaufen idea of sacred kingship confronts the Gregorian idea of papal hierarchy, it would be hard to decide if this is a case of a political or a religious conflict. As Walter Ullmann pointed out, the pope and the emperor refer both to the spiritual sphere because at the basis of their conflict lies a single question: Who is the true vicar of Christ on earth?⁸ The question presupposes the 'spiritual' question of the nature of Christ's heavenly rule. If the nature of this rule is the *ordo Melchisedech*, the unity of kingship and priesthood in the same person, a number of 'political' questions arise: Is the royal priest in heaven to be represented by two *officia* on earth, the *regnum* and the *sacerdotium*, held by different persons? Or must there be only one earthly *regale sacerdotium*, just as there is only one in heaven? In other words, are emperor and pope endowed with equal powers and yet rule over different spheres of *christianitas*? Or is the pope the true possessor of the spiritual and the temporal sword, who can delegate his temporal powers to secular rulers? Like all other political thinkers of the medieval West, Joachim of Fiore is deeply concerned with these questions, drawing his terminology from the standard sources such as the treatises of the popes Gelasius I and Gregory VII or from Bernard of Clairvaux's *De consideratione ad Eugenium papam*.

In the theoretical discussions which took place in the Latin West, the concept of the political (*politicum*) could not have played a role until after the twelfth century. When in the course of the rediscovery of Aristotle's *Politics* in the thirteenth century, it came into use again it could only have the anthropological meaning which it formerly held in classical philosophy and which, in its essential core, is not restricted to a certain cultural or historical context. Thomas Aquinas described man as the *animal sociale et politicum*, a being that because of its political nature differs from all other animals, who are merely social in nature.⁹ Humans do not just gather to survive, but to live a good

⁶ Friedrich Heer, *Aufgang Europas. Eine Studie zu den Zusammenhängen zwischen politischer Religiosität, Frömmigkeitsstil und dem Werden Europas im 12. Jahrhundert* (Vienna and Zurich, 1948), 10.

⁷ Friedrich Kempf, 'Das Problem der Christianitas im 12. und 13. Jahrhundert', *Historisches Jahrbuch der Görres-Gesellschaft*, 79 (1960), 104–23.

⁸ Walter Ullmann, *The Growth of Papal Government in the Middle Ages: A Study in the Ideological Relation of Clerical to Lay Power* (London, 1970), 264; cf. the discussion in Richard W. Southern, *Western Society and the Church in the Middle Ages* (Harmondsworth, 1970), 15–34.

⁹ Thomas Aquinas, *De regno*, i, 1, cit. *Divi Thomae Aquinatis De regimine principum ad regem Cypri et De regimine Judaeorum ad ducissam Brabantiae: politica opuscula duo* (Turin, 1924), 1; cf. Aristotle, *Politics*, 1253a.

life, a life that has a meaning beyond mere subsistence. Since humans are also the only animals whose social gatherings are not determined by their instincts but have the capacity to articulate their thoughts rationally, they are capable of jointly deliberating the ends of their society, the purpose governing their social order. Such anthropological understanding of the political is a definition which is closer to the historical origins of the concept than the modern state-centred understanding and can still be used by medieval historians without the danger of anachronism. Expressed in more theoretical terms, the political is the symbolic order by which a society expresses its self-interpretation. It is the meaningful dimension of human society. The political manifests itself in the social order of concrete historical societies; and these manifestations vary according to the experiences of order humans have in all dimensions of their existence, including the spiritual dimension.¹⁰

The Political Significance of Joachim's *Principium Concordiarum*¹¹

If the political is the meaningful dimension of human social order, then it follows that this manifests itself in church order as well as in the order of the empire. And even the order of *christianitas*, which encompasses temporal and spiritual powers, must be regarded as a political order. Consequently, one of the central problems of Christian political thought is the question of the relationship between temporal and spiritual powers within the order of *christianitas*.¹² The investiture controversy revealed that the pope and the emperor had very different views on the problem. These differences determined their self-understanding and consequently their politics. Gregory VII and his theological entourage promoted a new concept of *ecclesia* which downplayed the role of worldly

¹⁰ 'Das Politische umgreift und durchformt [...] die verschiedenen sozialen Lebenssphären ungeachtet des jeweiligen Differenzierungsgrades, insofern jedes politisch-symbolische Ordnungsgefüge die Gesamtexistenz des Menschen repräsentiert. Das heißt, alle politischen Gestaltungen artikulieren in unterschiedlicher Konstellation die Dimensionen des Menschlichen, die leiblich-physische, die affekt-psychische ebenso wie die intellektuelle und spirituell-religiöse Dimension.' Jürgen Gebhardt, 'Was ist der Gegenstand einer empirisch-hermeneutischen Theorie des Politischen?', in *Politische Theorie – heute. Ansätze und Perspektiven*, ed. Michael Th. Greven and Rainer Schmalz-Bruns (Baden-Baden, 1999), 101–19, at 109; 'Im Politischen offenbart sich jene der menschlichen Existenz eigene Dimension des Geistes und der Freiheit jenseits der biologischen Bedingtheit, der sich die Humanität des Menschen verdankt.' Ibid., 117; cf. Eric Voegelin, *Anamnesis. Theorie der Geschichte und der Politik* (Munich, 1966), 283–354.

¹¹ For a more detailed discussion, see my monograph *Joachim von Fiore – Denker der vollendeten Menschheit* (Würzburg, 2004).

¹² For an excellent overview of the medieval debates concerning this problem, see John A. Watt, 'Spiritual and Temporal Powers', in *The Cambridge History of Medieval Political Thought*, c. 350–c. 1450, ed. James H. Burns (Cambridge, 1988), 367–423.

rulers as charismatic members of the *corpus mysticum*. Rather, the papal side successively restricted the meaning of *ecclesia* to the clergy, the *ordo ecclesiasticus*, and treated the emperor as a lay person. This new understanding of *ecclesia* enabled the Gregorian movement to launch the struggle for the *libertas ecclesiae*, the liberation of the church from the hands of laymen.¹³ Another important political consequence of this conceptual shift was that the kings and emperors could now be seen as enemies of the church, even if they were Christians. But if they were indeed enemies of the church, they no longer differed significantly from others such as the pagan Roman emperors, the Jews, the Goths, the Vandals, and later the Lombards and the Muslims.

The new concept of the church as a sacred community which suffers persecution by worldly powers led also to a new, apocalyptic understanding of history. The non-apocalyptic reading of the Revelation of St John as found in Augustine's *City of God* determined its orthodox interpretation until the eleventh century. Augustine himself denied that the meaning of profane history could be understood by humans.¹⁴ He argued that it was possible to make judgements about the moral character of earthly powers, since the members of the *civitas Dei* and the *civitas terrena* are dispersed among all peoples and kingdoms. Profane history, according to Augustine, is determined by the fact that good and bad human beings are mixed up together (*hominum bonorum et malorum nunc permixtione*).¹⁵ The Day of Judgement alone would reveal the meaning of historical events.¹⁶ The millennium would only be a symbol for the Christian era and all calculations of history would be determined to fail.¹⁷

But this interpretation was to alter significantly as a result of the investiture controversy. The violent struggle between emperor and pope destroyed the symbolical unity of spiritual and temporal powers within the Christian *sacrum imperium*. Commentators on the Apocalypse, such as Bruno of Segni, Rupert of Deutz, Anselm of Havelberg, and Gerhoch of Reichersberg, tried to discover the meaning of the contemporary conflicts in the prophetic verses of the Revelation of John.¹⁸ Gradually the idea became predominant that the Apocalypse contained in encoded form the entire history of the church, including future events. According to the new generation of commentators, the conflicts between church and empire were to be regarded as episodes in the struggle between the people of

¹³ Joseph Lortz, *Geschichte der Kirche in ideengeschichtlicher Betrachtung*, vol. 1: *Altertum und Mittelalter* (Munster, 1962), 296.

¹⁴ Augustine, *De civitate Dei*, lib. xx, cap. 2, CCSL 48, 701.

¹⁵ Augustine, *De civitate Dei*, lib. xx, cap. 5, CCSL 48, 703f.

¹⁶ Augustine, *De civitate Dei*, lib. xx, cap. 2, CCSL 48, 701.

¹⁷ Augustine, *De civitate Dei*, lib. xx, cap. 7, CCSL 48, 710–12; lib. xx, cap. 9, 718.

¹⁸ The best overview of the shifts in the interpretation of the Revelation of John is still to be found in: Wilhelm Kamlah, *Apokalypse und Geschichtstheologie. Die mittelalterliche Auslegung der Apokalypse vor Joachim von Fiore* (Berlin, 1935).

God and the worldly forces, directed by the Antichrist. As Bernard McGinn has emphasized, apocalyptic prophecy in the high Middle Ages was not primarily a heretical phenomenon; indeed, many of the commentators on the apocalypse, including Joachim of Fiore, served as political advisors to the popes: 'Rather than representing a semi-educated and alienated fringe of society, most of the major apocalyptic thinkers of the twelfth century were figures situated in high echelons of intellectual and political power. They sought to make their views effective both on a popular level through preaching and also with the leadership of *christianitas*, especially with the popes of the era.'¹⁹

Joachim of Fiore claimed to have found a key to the code of the Apocalypse, which would allow him to reveal the meaning of past, present, and future events more precisely. In one of his later writings, he called this methodological key the *principium concordiarum*.²⁰ *Concordia* means the structural equivalence of Old and New Testament, whereby 'New Testament' signifies the whole course of church history. Joachim himself defined *concordia* as the similarity of equal proportions (*similitudo eque proportionis*).²¹ According to this principle, every period, event, or person described in the Old Testament corresponds to an equivalent period, event, or person in the New Testament.

Joachim refers to the vision of John of Patmos, in which Christ receives from the Father a book with seven seals. Like other commentators, Joachim recognizes the seven seals as the basic structure of the Apocalypse. He explains that every major tribulation found in the Old Testament is symbolically represented by one of the seals and every seal opened by Christ means an analogous tribulation in the history of Christianity.²² Consequently, the series of the seven seals (*sigilla*) and seven openings (*apertiones*) constitutes the parallel structures of the Old and the New Testament. In other words, the Old Testament is the key to understanding the enigmatic prophecies of the Apocalypse. Already in his first known work, the *Genealogia*, the abbot shows that all major attacks carried out by the worldly powers against the church, the new people of God, are anticipated in the history of Israel, the old people of God:

¹⁹ Bernard McGinn, 'Apocalypticism and Church Reform: 1100–1500', in *The Encyclopedia of Apocalypticism*, vol. 2: *Apocalypticism in Western History and Culture*, ed. Bernard McGinn (New York, 1999), 74–109, at 85.

²⁰ Joachim of Fiore, *Intelligentia super calathis*, ed. Pietro de Leo, *Gioacchino da Fiore. Aspetti inediti della vita e delle opere* (Soveria Mannelli, 1988), 135–48, at 135.

²¹ 'Concordiam proprie esse dicimus similitudinem eque proportionis noui ac ueteris testamenti; eque dico quo ad numerum, non quo ad dignitatem; cum uidelicet persona et persona, ordo et ordo, bellum et bellum ex parilitate quadam mutuis se uultibus intuentur: utpote Abraham et Zacharias, Sara et Elisabeth, Isaac et Iohannes baptista, Iacob et homo Christus Ihesus, duodecim patriarche et numeri eiusdem apostoli [...]', Joachim of Fiore, *Liber de Concordia Noui ac Veteris Testamenti*, ed. E. Randolph Daniel, *Transactions of the American Philosophical Society*, 73/8 (Philadelphia, 1983), 3–435, at 62.

²² Rev. 5:1–7; 6; 8:1–5

In the Old Testament, the first fight was with the Egyptians; the second with the Cananeans; the third with Syrians, the fourth with the Assyrians; the fifth with the Chaldeans; the sixth fight was the one the Medes fought against the Babylonians and then against the children of Israel; the seventh was the fight with the Greeks, when Antiochus expelled [the Jews from] Jerusalem. These seven tribulations were the seven seals, that is, the hidden seals of the things to come. Because nobody knew how to open them until Christ came.

These wars were fought against the children of Israel. In a similar way, the Jews waged a war against the church when the first seal was opened; the second war was the persecution by the pagans; the Syrians can be compared to the Persians, Goths, Vandals, and Lombards, who attacked the church; at the fourth seal, the Saracens rose up against the church; at the fifth seal the new Chaldeans and the new Babylon rose up against the spiritual Jerusalem; at the sixth seal happens the destruction of Babylon, that is Rome. As I said above, seven tribulations happened [in the Old Testament], but the last two are to be understood as one. The tribulation of Antiochus can be compared to the one that will be done by the Antichrist.²³

After Joachim in this way decoded the basic structure of church history, he developed more exact methods in order to make his interpretation of past and present events, as well as his prediction of future events, more precise. Using a complicated exegetical procedure, he calculated two parallel lines of generations (*generationes*). The length of the carnal generations of the Old Testament depends on the length of the lives of the patriarchs or the duration of the governments of the rulers. The spiritual generations of the New Testament last exactly 30 years, according to the time that passed between the incarnation of Christ and his procreation of spiritual children by public preaching. Here the political significance of Joachim's exegesis becomes clear. With the help of the *principium concordiarum* it would be possible to identify which Old Testament rulers corresponded to those in the present day. Moreover, it became possible to predict the future development of contemporary conflicts and give advice to popes or rulers accordingly.

For example, in his later work *Intelligentia super calathis*, Joachim drew a parallel between the situation of the papal court in the year 1191 and that of Israel in the year 587 BC. The German troops were to be regarded as the new Babylonians, and King Henry VI as the new Nebuchadnezzar. Joachim himself acted as the new Jeremiah. He brought the prophecies of his 'predecessor' up to date and told the curia how to react to the recent demands of the German king:

²³ Joachim of Fiore, *Genealogia*, ed. Gian Luca Potestà, 'Die Genealogia. Ein frühes Werk Joachims von Fiore und die Anfänge seines Geschichtsbildes', *Deutsches Archiv für Erforschung des Mittelalters*, 56 (2000), 55–101, at 95–6. Unless indicated otherwise, all translations from Joachim are my own.

the will of the king has to be done and he has to be crowned Emperor of the Romano-German Empire, since it was the will of God that Israel had obeyed the command of Nebuchadnezzar and accepted the Babylonian captivity.²³

This example also points to another political dimension of Joachim's reading of the Apocalypse. The abbot contradicts the self-understanding of those Christian kings who used to regard themselves as the successors of the anointed kings of Israel. According to Joachim's exegesis, the popes were the true successors of the Jewish kings of the Old Testament, since they are true rulers of the new people of God. Jesus Christ, who, according to the Gospel of Matthew, is heir to King David, brings to a close the line of the Old Testament rulers and, at the same time, founds the royal priesthood of the popes. The worldly rulers, on the other hand, correspond to the pagan rulers of the Old Testament who were on either good or bad terms with Israel. Of course, this interpretation of worldly rule was a consequence of the new Gregorian concept of the church. If the church consists primarily of its ordained members, the kings and emperors cannot play a significant role in the government of *christianitas*. As Joachim writes, rulers have to offer their services (*ministeria*) to the church.²⁵ But if they act against the will of the curia, they have to be put on a level with the enemies of Israel.

In other words, Joachim's early interpretation of the Bible and church history has a clear political agenda: It provides an exegetical basis for the legitimization of papal leadership and the downgrading of the earthly rulers in the charismatic order of the *corpus Christi*. Joachim clearly takes sides in the symbolical struggle between emperor and pope. The royal priesthood (*sacerdotium regale*) is the inheritance of the popes. The pope is not only the successor of Peter but also the vicar of Christ on earth. However, he unites the highest spiritual and temporal powers in his person; but Joachim agrees with Bernard of Clairvaux that the pope should delegate his temporal power to the secular rulers. Joachim sums up his political agenda in the *Liber Concordiae*, commenting on the Sylvester legend, a story which he and his contemporaries perceived as a historical fact:

One has to know that the man Jesus Christ, who is anointed by the Holy Spirit and rules the Christian people, is at the same time king and priest. Consequently, Peter tells the ones who belong to Christ: 'But you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood [*regale sacerdotium*], since the royal majesty belongs to the divinity [of Christ], the humility

²³ For interpretations of the *Intelligentia super calathis*, see Herbert Grundmann, 'Kirchenfreiheit und Kaisermacht um 1190', in id., *Ausgewählte Aufsätze Teil 2: Joachim von Fiore*, Schriften der Monumenta Germaniae Historica 25/2 (Stuttgart, 1977), 360–402; Riedl, *Joachim von Fiore*, 168–203; Julia Eva Wannenmacher, *Hermeneutik der Heilsgeschichte. De septem sigillis und das Motiv der sieben Siegel im Werk Joachims von Fiore*, Studies in the History of Christian Traditions, 118 (Leiden and Boston, 2005), 148–55.

²⁵ Joachim of Fiore, *Intelligentia*, 136. The edition of De Leo has *misteria* instead of *ministeria*. For a correction of the text, see Grundmann, 'Kirchenfreiheit', 372–3.

of the priest to his humanity. Therefore, the Psalmist said: 'You are a priest for ever after the order of Melchisedech, since Melchisedech was a priest of the Lord and king of Salem. Accordingly, the Roman pope had to be king and priest at the same time. Emperor Constantine, who understood this, voluntarily offered to the holy pope Sylvester the dignity which he seemed to hold as if he owed it to Christ. But since the kingship of Christ is not of this world, it appeared to the popes as if they always had received their due power [*debita potestas*] from Christ. Nevertheless, they were forced to leave the temporal use of their kingship – or better: the bodily burden of their government [*regimen*] – to the ones who strive for the glory of this world. So, according to the apostle, the ones that strive for God will not be involved in temporal business.'²⁶

Psalterium Decem Chordarum: The Paradigm of Heavenly Order

An adequate study of Joachim's main works, the *Liber Concordiae*, the *Psalterium decem chordarum*, and the *Exposition in Apocalypsim*, must recognize the fact that the abbot relates all his exegetical novelties to visionary or mystical experiences. Already the *principium concordiarum* is, according to Joachim, the result of a vision.²⁷ The *Psalterium decem chordarum*, on the other hand, is the interpretation of another vision which Joachim recounts in the preface of the book. In 1183 Joachim was a guest at the Cistercian monastery of Casamari during Pentecost. While he was reciting the Psalms, he suddenly felt doubts about the doctrine of the Holy Trinity, namely that there are three persons but only one God. He invoked the Holy Spirit to come to his aid in his crisis and indeed had a vision:

Without delay the form of the ten-stringed psaltery appeared in my mind, and in it the very mystery of the Holy Trinity, so bright and clear, that I was immediately forced to exclaim: 'What god is great like our God? Thou art the God who workest wonders', and: 'Great is our Lord, and abundant in power; his understanding is beyond measure.'²⁸

The ten-stringed psaltery, the instrument King David used to accompany his singing of the Psalms, appeared in Joachim's vision as an image of the divine Trinity and the entire heavenly order.²⁹ Table XIII of the *Liber figurarum*, which

²⁶ Joachim of Fiore, *Concordia*, ed. Daniel, 329; cf. 1 Pet. 2:9; Ps. 110:4; Gen. 14: 18; John 18:36; 2 Tim. 2:4.

²⁷ Joachim of Fiore, *Concordia*, ed. Daniel, 146.

²⁸ Joachim of Fiore, *Psalterium decem chordarum* (Venice, 1527), fol. 227va; ed. Kurt-Victor Selge, *Joachim von Fiore. Psalterium decem chordarum*, MGH, Quellen zur Geistesgeschichte des Mittelalters 20 (Hannover, 2009), 6–355, at 10, Ps. 77:14–15; 147: 5.

²⁹ See Ps. 33:2; 92:4.

is directly related to Joachim's vision, shows a triangular string instrument with a flattened top corner.³⁰ According to Joachim, the flattened top represents the Father, the origin of all being, and the two corners at the bottom represent the Son and the Spirit. The perfect circle of the sound hole symbolizes the perfect unity (*unitas perfecta*) of the Trinity.³¹ The 10 strings represent the 10 ranks of the heavenly order. The strings of the psaltery become shorter towards the top, representing the hierarchy of the heavenly society. The masses dwell in the lower ranks while elites occupy the upper ranks.³² Nevertheless, all ranks unite to praise God; and the sound of their songs permeates the whole psaltery and resonates in the corners of the instrument to please all three persons of the Trinity.

By symbolizing the heavenly order in the psaltery, Joachim shows that he agrees with the general medieval idea of creation: the meaning of creation is to praise the creator. The heavenly order of praise was perfect until Satan and the apostate angels rebelled against their creator and fell out of the order. God created man to fill this gap in the heavenly choir of praise and, once proving himself worthy, even stand above the nine angelic ranks of the heavenly order.³³ This is why, in the image of psaltery as found in the *Liber figurarum*, Joachim calls the tenth and highest string *homo*. The fall of Adam sabotaged the divine plan. However, it could not prevent its final fulfilment because God decided to reveal himself to mankind in the long process of history in order to remind them of the meaning of their existence. Consequently, history has one single goal: mankind must gradually regain the condition which makes it worthy of entering the afterlife and joining in with the heavenly hymns of praise.

Accordingly, the paradigm of the heavenly order determines the meaning and end of the human social order in this world. Joachim was convinced that only someone to whom the Holy Spirit had given the charismatically gift of insight into the invisible things (*invisibilia*) of heaven, knows how the visible things (*visibilia*) on earth should be ordered to satisfy the divine will. Therefore it is impossible to distinguish between theological and political ideas in Joachim's thought of order. His teachings about human society spring from his contemplative and visionary insights into the divine order: Christianity is perfectly ordered if it praises God in the most perfect way.

The heavenly paradigm prompts Joachim to reformulate the model of medieval society. He rearranges the three orders according to the principle of achievement. Only monks, who dedicate their life to God and manage to sing

³⁰ Joachim of Fiore, *Liber figurarum*, ed. Leone Tondelli, Marjorie Reeves and Beatrice Hirsch-Reich, *Il libro delle figure dell'abate Gioacchino da Fiore*, 2 vols (Turin, 1953), ii, tav. xiii.

³¹ Joachim of Fiore, *Psalterium*, fol. 232vb–233ra, ed. Selge, 43.

³² Joachim of Fiore, *Psalterium*, fol. 243ra–rb, ed. Selge, 111.

³³ 'Nota quod homo prelati est omnibus ordinibus angelorum propter verbum patris humanam carnem assumens, ut gradum chorde decimum qui corrui restauraret.' (Ps.-)Joachim of Fiore, *Psalterium* (re vera *Praemissiones*), fol. 226r, cf. ed. Selge, LXIX.

all 150 Psalms in one day, deserve the highest social rank. Clerics, who engage in the *vita activa* and are burdened with preaching and pastoral care, must be of a lower rank. Lay people, who have to take care of bodily needs and have only little time to praise God, find themselves at the bottom of society.³⁴

Joachim, of course, realizes that the social reality of his time does not fit the paradigm, but is convinced that such a society will be achieved in the future, as soon as the divine process of revelation and education has come to an end. A few words about Joachim's theology of revelation will make his argument clearer. In accordance with doctrine, he believed that Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are three persons but one essence. Therefore the divine persons do not differ in substance, quality, and quantity; rather their individual property (*proprietas*) is determined by their relation (*relatio*) to the other persons.³⁵ Joachim describes the *proprietates* as processions (*processiones*) within the divinity, according to the image of the psaltery: the two lines that take their starting point from the flattened corner of the Father symbolize the two *processiones* by which the Son and the Holy Spirit proceed from the Father. The property of the Father is that he does not proceed from another person but the two other persons proceed from him. The property of the Son is that he proceeds from the Father while the Holy Spirit proceeds from him. Finally, the property of the Holy Spirit is that it proceeds from the Father and the Son (*filioque*).³⁶ However, all these processions are eternal and do not happen in time since the coeternity (*coeternitas*) of the three persons follows from their being of the same substance,

In order to appear to intelligible man, who exists in time, the eternal processions must manifest themselves in the historical process of divine revelation. Consequently, the processions inside the divinity correspond to the temporal missions (*missiones*) of the Son and the Holy Spirit. Joachim believed that these missions, too, were shown to him on the occasion of the vision of the psaltery:

The fact that this [flattened] corner is the principal one and apparently differs slightly from the other two seems to teach us that the Father, since he does not proceed from any other [person], will never be sent to man; at any rate he has no origin [*principium*] from which he could be sent. But the Son and the Spirit, who flow into the heavenly

³⁴ Joachim of Fiore, *Psalterium*, fol. 245ra–va, ed. Selge, 122–5.

³⁵ Joachim of Fiore, *Psalterium*, fol. 230vb, 258va, ed. Selge, 28–30, 206–7.

³⁶ The formula 'the Spirit proceeds from the Father and the Son', the so-called 'Filioque', was the occasion of the Greek schism and again heavily debated in Joachim's time. At the Fourth Lateran Council of 1215 the 'Filioque' was declared Catholic doctrine. Cf. Bernd Oberdorfer, *Filioque. Geschichte und Theologie eines ökumenischen Problems*, *Forschungen zur systematischen und ökumenischen Theologie* 96 (Göttingen, 2001), and Peter Gemeinhardt, 'Joachim the Theologian. Trinitarian Speculation and Doctrinal Debate', in *Companion to Joachim of Fiore*, ed. Matthias Riedl and Julia Eva Wannenmacher (forthcoming).

city and fill the nine choirs of the angels with their grace, flow further down like the current of a river in order to redeem mankind.³⁷

The missions of the Son and the Spirit reveal to man an increasing knowledge about the divine reality. In this way, mankind gradually progresses from the ignorance which resulted from the fall of Adam. At the end of this process mankind will enter heaven, climb the tenth string of the psalter, and rank above the nine choirs of the angels. To Joachim, redemption means participation in the eternal praise of God – as it is said in Psalm 84: 'Blessed are those who dwell in thy house, ever singing thy praise!'³⁸

Joachim's interpretation of his vision of the psalter raised two significant questions. First, how will it come about that the earthly institution of the future church corresponds to the heavenly paradigm? How can monks, who contribute the greatest part to the praise of God, take the highest position of Christian society? Second, if the New Testament recounts the temporal mission of the Son, how will the mission of the Spirit become manifest? Only another unexpected illumination would solve these problems.

The Easter Experience

When he started working on the *Psalterium decem chordarum*, Joachim had already begun to write a complete commentary on the Revelation of John. However, he did not progress very far because he was unable to disclose the meaning of the tenth verse of the first chapter. In this verse John of Patmos describes the pneumatic experience which initiated his apocalyptic visions: 'I was in the Spirit on the Lord's day (*fui in spiritu in dominica die*).'³⁹ Then, during the Easter of 1185, the breakthrough happened. Joachim reports the event as follows:

About the middle of the night's silence, as I think, the hour when it is thought that our Lion of the tribe of Judah rose from the dead, as I was meditating, suddenly something of the fullness of the book and of the entire harmony of the Old and New Testaments was perceived with clarity of understanding in my mind's eye.³⁹

Joachim explicitly says that he received a revelation (*mihi revelatio facta est*), though its content is not important for the present discussion. The harmony of

³⁷ Joachim of Fiore, *Psalterium*, fol. 236ra, ed. Selge, 63–4.

³⁸ Joachim of Fiore, *Psalterium*, fol. 227ra, ed. Selge, 7.

³⁹ Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio in Apocalypsim* (Venice, 1527), fol. 39va. The English translation of this quotation is taken from Bernard McGinn, *The Calabrian Abbot: Joachim of Fiore in the History of Western Thought* (New York, 1985), 21–2.

the testaments had always been the foundation of his exegetical work. As with the 'fullness' (*plenitudo*) of the Apocalypse, Joachim's conviction had always been that the Revelation of John contains in encoded form all sacred history. What is important is that he believed that he had repeated the pneumatic experience of John of Patmos. Joachim himself was 'in the spirit on the Lord's day'.⁴⁰

Looking back, Joachim related a number of decisive insights to his Easter experience. One of these insights is of particular interest: Joachim says that he learned that 'Christ, who leaves his grave, signifies the spirit that proceeds from the letter [*Christus de monumento egrediens spiritum de littera signaverit processurus*]'.⁴¹ The fact that Joachim speaks again of the procession of the spirit points to the processions inside the divinity which he described in the *Psalterium decem chordarum*. Joachim now believed that he had understood the way in which God manifests his Trinitarian essence in the process of revelation.

Just as the Son proceeds from the Father, the letter of the New Testament proceeds from the letter of the Old Testament. Just as the Spirit proceeds from the Father and the Son, spiritual understanding (*intellectus spiritualis*) proceeds from the Old and the New Testaments. The Father reveals himself particularly in the Old Testament and the Son in the New Testament. The Spirit, however, will have its own time, in which human understanding will transcend the letter of the Bible. Joachim refers to the Gospel of John where Christ says: 'I have yet many things to say to you, but you cannot bear them now. When the Spirit of truth comes, he will guide you into all the truth; for he will not speak on his own authority, but whatever he hears he will speak, and he will declare to you the things that are to come.'⁴² At the end of the revelatory process mankind will regain the knowledge which it had lost because of Adam's sin:

Thus it is proper for mankind after the guilt of the first man to return gradually [*gradatim*] to the cognition of its creator; so it may be rooted in the first time of the Father, grow in the second time of the Son and experience the sweet fruit in the third age of the Holy Spirit.⁴³

The Easter of 1185 marks the beginning of this new stage in the process of revelation, the beginning of the third age of the world (*tertius status mundi*). Joachim was so much convinced about the significance of his Easter experience

⁴⁰ Cf. Robert Lerner, 'Joachim of Fiore's Breakthrough to Chiliasm', *Cristianesimo nella storia*, 6 (1985), 459–512, at 494.

⁴¹ Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio*, fol. 39va.

⁴² John 16:12–13; cf. Joachim of Fiore, *Liber concordiae Novi ac Veteris Testamenti* (Venice, 1519), fol. 112rb; Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio*, fol. 86rb–va.

⁴³ Joachim of Fiore, *Praepatio super Apocalypsim*, ed. Kurt-Victor Selge, 'Eine Einführung Joachims von Fiore in die Johannesapokalypse', *Deutsches Archiv für Erforschung des Mittelalters*, 46/1 (1990), 85–131, at 102.

that he regarded himself as being positioned at the beginning of the third *status* (*in initio tertii status positi sumus*).⁴⁴ Just as the first Easter event, the resurrection of Christ, initiated the second *status* the second Easter event, Joachim's revelation, initiated the third *status*. Joachim even says that his lifetime is the end of the old times and the beginning of the new times (*quantum ad vetera finis [...] et quantum ad nova principium subsequentium saeculorum*).⁴⁵ In the *Liber concordiae*, he expresses his consciousness of progress with an almost endless number of metaphors.⁴⁶

It is evident that Joachim's consciousness of epoch contradicts the traditional Augustinian idea of history. The age of the church, initiated by Christ, is no longer an age which is passing away (*saeculum senescens*); rather it is the preliminary stage for a time of spiritual fullness (*plenitudo intellectus*) which anticipates the heavenly *visio Dei*. Consequently, Joachim had to revise Augustine's doctrine of world ages. According to Augustine, the time between Adam and Christ comprised five ages (*aetates*) and with Christ started the sixth age. The seventh age, the sabbath of the people of God, signified the eternal bliss of the beyond.⁴⁷ Joachim, on the other hand, transferred the seventh *aetas* into this world and identified it with the third *status*, whereas the final redemption in the beyond was to be seen as an eighth age. The seventh age, however, would anticipate the glory of the heavenly Jerusalem (*pars quaedam claritatis Ierusalem manifesta erit in septima, et tota generaliter in octava*) and bring about a social order which would, even in details, correspond to the heavenly paradigm.⁴⁸

[...] in the seventh age, even the smallest detail of the structure of Jerusalem will be completed just as the convocation of all the people that will dwell in it [*perficiatur in septima, quicquid minus erit in structura Ierusalem, et vocatione universi populi, qui*

⁴⁴ Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio*, fol. 39rb.

⁴⁵ Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio*, fol. 39vb.

⁴⁶ 'Tres denique mundi status nobis, ut iam scripsimus in hoc opere, divine pagine sacramenta commendant. primum, in quo fuimus sub lege; secundum, in quo sumus sub gratia; tertium, quod e vicino expectamus, sub ampliori gratia, quia gratiam, inquit Iohannes, pro gratia dedit nobis, fidem scilicet pro caritate, etsi simul utrumque. primum ergo status in scientia fuit, secundus in parte sapientie, tertius in plenitudine intellectus. primum in servitute servili, secundus in servitute filiali, tertius in libertate. primum in flagellis, secundus in actione, tertius in contemplatione. primum in timore, secundus in fide, tertius in caritate. primum status servorum est, secundus liberorum, tertius amicorum. primum puerorum, secundus iuvenum, tertius senum. primum in luce syderum, secundus in aurora, tertius in perfecto die. primum in hyeme, secundus in exordio veris, tertius in estate. primum protuler urticas, secundus rosas, tertius lilia. primum herbas, secundus spicas, tertius triticum. primum aquam, secundus vinum, tertius oleum.' Joachim of Fiore, *Concordia*, fol. 112rb–va.

⁴⁷ Augustine, *De civitate Dei*, lib. xxii, 30, CCL 48, 866.

⁴⁸ Joachim of Fiore, *Enchiridion super Apocalypsim*, ed. Edward Kilian Burger, *Pontifical Institute of Mediaeval Studies and Texts* 78 (Toronto, 1986), 49.

futurus est in ea) – insofar as in the future world, which will be like an eighth age, everything will evidently be fulfilled, which is related to this [convocation].⁴⁹

Thus, after the Easter experience, the main task of Joachim's exegetical efforts was no longer to show the harmony between the two testaments, but to interpret the Bible in order to 'make known the order and the progress by which God directs his works toward the end of times [*ut ostenderemus, quo ordine et quo profectus deus perduxerit opera sua ad fines saeculorum*]'.⁵⁰

Joachim's Idea of Social Progress

The Easter experience created a new self-understanding. Joachim was now convinced that he was one of the spiritual men (*virī spirituales*) poised at the watershed of times and about to receive a higher spiritual knowledge which will gradually become a knowledge common to all in the third *status*. But if knowledge about the divine order in heaven was to increase, so, too, would knowledge about the ideal order of earthly society. Joachim recognizes that neither the social order of the clergy nor the monastic orders corresponded to the heavenly paradigm. Not even the Cistercian order, which had achieved the most in praising God, was part of the paradigm. Joachim draws the practical consequences, gathers a number of his adherents, and climbs the Sila Mountains to found the new Florentian order. The Florentians regard themselves as the avant-garde of the third *status*; they anticipate the developments that would soon take place in the entire church.⁵¹ Joachim prophesies that in the near future Christianity will transform itself into a universal spiritual church (*ecclesia spiritualis*) dominated by monks, by those who devote their life to the praise of God.

Joachim understands an historically changing Christian society as the expression of the increasing knowledge provided by God's gradual self-revelation. In other words, the more God reveals about himself, the more perfect the social order becomes – until finally the society of the spiritual church mirrors the heavenly order. In this way, Joachim of Fiore is the first political thinker to work out a theory of social progress. He goes even further when he predicts that the order of mankind in the third *status* will be perfect and fulfil the will of God in every respect (*perfectio hominum illius status, in quibus fient omnia ordinatae secundum praeceptum domini*), even though he has to admit that this perfection is limited like all earthly things and is only a temporal anticipation of the eternal

⁴⁹ Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio*, fol. 221rb.

⁵⁰ Joachim of Fiore, *Concordia*, ed. Daniel, 306.

⁵¹ Cf. Stephen E. Wesley, "Bonum est Benedicto mutare locum": The Role of the "Life of Saint Benedict" in Joachim of Fiore's Monastic Reform, *Revue Bénédictine*, 90 (1980), 314–28.

perfection in the beyond.⁵² The following paragraphs will take a closer look at the single stages in Joachim's theory of social progress.

After the Fall

Joachim describes the *condicio humana* after the fall as a dark night of ignorance.⁵³ The expulsion from Paradise means primarily an intellectual loss, since the human beings lost knowledge of the creator, and consequently knowledge of the meaning of their existence. They only have a faint idea of a superior power, experiencing their situation only in terms of punishment. God does not yet reveal himself to a chosen people but only to individuals such as Noah. At this stage of history it is hardly possible to speak of social order because all ordering of society is the result of the knowledge about the divine. According to their faint and diffuse idea of God, mankind looks like a single undifferentiated and unstructured mass.⁵⁴

The First Status

The fall of man cannot prevent God from fulfilling his plan. Man is the summit of creation and created according in the image of God. He is supposed to fill the gap caused by the fall of Satan and his adherents, and to adorn the heavenly court for the glory of God. That is why the creator starts to reveal himself and to commend the knowledge about the divine things. Of course, at this point of history mankind is in a childlike stage of its development and can never comprehend the fullness of the triune divinity. Therefore, God first reveals himself as the Father because he has to teach discipline to mankind and make it obedient by means of his fatherly punishment. Only hereafter can mankind progress to higher stages of understanding.⁵⁵ God now reveals himself first of all to the chosen people. Just as with a child, he provides Israel with the simple rules of the Ten Commandments in order to show it how to behave according to the will of the Father.⁵⁶ The first *status* already starts with Abraham, who receives the commandment of circumcision. The symbolic meaning of the circumcision is that the ancient people of God still have carnal knowledge of divine revelation. Because Israel knows nothing of the perfection of society in the afterlife, its political goal is to establish a messianic empire on earth. Abraham and his family

⁵² Joachim of Fiore, *Concordia*, fol. 96rb.

⁵³ Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio*, fol. 5va–vb.

⁵⁴ Joachim of Fiore, *Enchiridion*, 23.

⁵⁵ Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio*, fol. 67vb; *Psalterium*, fol. 246vb, ed. Selge, 133–5.

⁵⁶ Joachim of Fiore, *Concordia*, fol. 111ra; Joachim of Fiore, *Tractatus super quatuor evangelia*, ed. Francesco Santi, *Joachim abbas Florentis Opera Omnia* 5, Fonti per la storia dell'Italia medievale (Rome, 2002), 25.

are the paradigm of the social order in the first *status*. Since God first revealed himself as the Father, the social form of Israel is patriarchal.⁵⁷

The Second Status

The mission of the Son initiates a new stage in the process of revelation. Christ reveals to humans the otherworldly goal of their lives, the eternal life. The new people of God no longer strive for a messianic empire on earth but for the heavenly Jerusalem, even though knowledge of heavenly things is still incomplete. The new order of clerics emerges and assumes a social form according to the model of Christ himself. The clerics imitate not only the priesthood of Christ but also his continence. Like Christ, the clerics are procreated but do not procreate. Instead, they create spiritual offspring by preaching and administering the sacraments.⁵⁸

The Third Status

In the future age of the Spirit a higher knowledge, which is already at work in spiritual men like Joachim, will proceed from the Bible:

Just as the letter of the Old Testament seems, because of a certain proper similarity, to correspond to the Father, and the letter of the New Testament corresponds to the Son, the spiritual intelligence [*spiritualis intelligentia*], which proceeds from the two, corresponds to the Holy Spirit.⁵⁹

A number of passages in the work of Joachim suggest that the new spiritual understanding differs decisively from all other forms of gaining knowledge. The reading of books, including the Bible, will no longer be necessary where the divine Spirit provides immediate knowledge about the heavenly things.⁶⁰ The celebration of the sacraments will lose its importance because the mysteries, which are enclosed in the sacraments, will be open and completely understandable.⁶¹

It must be acknowledged that in the third status the mysteries will lie naked and open before the eyes of the believers because, in the course of the ages of the world, knowledge will be multiplied [*scientia multiplicatur*].⁶²

⁵⁷ Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio*, fol. 18vb.

⁵⁸ Joachim of Fiore, *Concordia*, ed. Daniel, 256–8 and 406; *Expositio*, fol. 18vb.

⁵⁹ Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio*, fol. 5rb.

⁶⁰ Cf., e.g., Joachim of Fiore, *Concordia*, fol. 103va, *Praephatio*, 103.

⁶¹ Cf. Herbert Grundmann, 'Lex und Sacramentum bei Joachim von Fiore', in idem., *Ausgewählte Aufsätze Teil 2*, 403–20.

⁶² Joachim of Fiore, *Concordia*, fol. 96va.

This peculiar form of knowledge determines the society of the third *status*. Clerics will lose their eminent position while monks will dominate the new spiritual church. Nevertheless, the social orders of the previous two *status*, the clerics and the laity, will continue to exist. Lay people will still be necessary for the bodily procreation of children and in order to secure the material subsistence of the other two orders. But if there are lay people, there must also be clerics who engage in pastoral care. In other words, the church of the third *status* has to be regarded as a hierarchical society which is divided into three orders. But this society meets all requirements of a perfect order. Firstly, it corresponds to the hierarchical order of the heavenly paradigm. Secondly, the social rank of the individual orders is determined by their achievements in praising God, with monks occupying the top rank, clerics an intermediate position, and lay people the lowest.

Joachim's conception of a perfect society is guided by the biblical word that God created man in his own image.⁶³ In the third *status*, at the end of a long historical process of revelation and education, man will regain his likeness with the creator, which he lost after the fall. But man will regain this likeness not as an individual but within the collective of the Christian society. Of course, at the end of history, Christian society will comprehend virtually all mankind. As was shown above, each of the three social orders has a special relation to one of the three persons of the Trinity but the unity of Christian society corresponds to the unity of the divinity:

[...] just as the order of the married [lay] people [*ordo coniugatorum*], which becomes manifest in the first age, seems to correspond to the Father because of his proper similarity, and just as the order of the preachers [*ordo praedicatorum*], which becomes manifest in the second age, corresponds to the Son, the order of the monks [*ordo monachorum*], to which are particularly given the last ages, corresponds to the Holy Spirit. Accordingly, the first *status* is ascribed to the Father, the second to the Son, and the third to the Holy Spirit; but one must also say, that there is just one *status* of the world and only one people of the elect, and that all [orders] pertain at the same time to the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit.⁶⁴

Joachim's theory of progress in human society is even more complex. As a monk himself, he has to demonstrate why the monastic order already exists in early Christianity instead of emerging at the beginning of the third *status*. Therefore, Joachim includes in the doctrine of the three *status* the idea of certain starting times (*initiationes*), in which a social avant-garde anticipates the dominating

⁶³ Gen. 1:27.

⁶⁴ Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio*, fol. 5rb–va.

order of the following *status*.⁶⁵ The idea implies that the avant-garde anticipates the revelation which, in the future, will be available to everybody. Accordingly, Joachim says that God reveals himself to a small number of elect even before Abraham. In this way, Noah becomes a forerunner of the patriarchs of Israel. In the first *status*, King Uzziah forced his way into the temple and tried to usurp priestly powers, and, like Melchizedek, the king of Salem, he anticipated the royal priesthood of Christ and the clerics.⁶⁶ In another way, the priestly tribe of the Levites also anticipates the clerical order of the second *status*. The monastic order, however, must have two starting times, just as the Spirit proceeds from the Father and the Son. Joachim writes that the monastic order proceeds not only from the clerical church of the second *status* but also from the lay people of Israel. The prophets of the Old Testament anticipate the monastic way of living. Elijah is the Archetype of the anchorites as well as Elisha and his students practise an early form of cloistered living.⁶⁷

Conclusion

Since the political has been described above as the meaningful dimension of social order, the basic idea of Joachim's political thought can be expressed as follows. The progressive self-revelation of God motivates and determines the historical process of social advancement. In the final stage of the third *status*, this process will bring about the perfect political order which corresponds to the paradigm of heavenly order and reflects the essence of God. What the perfect political order exactly looks like can be studied in the detailed sketch of a constitution, which Joachim provides in the *Liber figurarum*.⁶⁸ The title of the constitution shows that the political perfection anticipates the order of the beyond. It says: 'The Constitution of the New Order Pertaining to the Third Status after the Model of the Heavenly Jerusalem [*Dispositio novi ordinis pertinens ad tertium statum ad instar supernae Ierusalem*]'.

The details of Joachim's constitution cannot be discussed here; it is more important to reconstruct the essential steps of his political thought after the spiritual experiences of the Pentecost of 1183 and the Easter of 1185. It is

⁶⁵ Joachim of Fiore, *Expositio*, fol. 5rb; Joachim of Fiore, *Concordia*, ed. Daniel, 66–7; *Concordia*, fol. 65va.

⁶⁶ Joachim of Fiore, *Concordia*, ed. Daniel, 68, 84, and 93; cf. 2 Kgs. 14:21–2; 15:1–7; 2 Chr. 26:1–27; 2; Gen. 14:18.

⁶⁷ Joachim of Fiore, *Concordia*, ed. Daniel, 74–5 and 77.

⁶⁸ Joachim of Fiore, *Liber figurarum*, tav. xii. An English translation of the constitution can be found in Bernard McGinn, *Apocalyptic Spirituality: Treatises and Letters of Lactantius, Adso of Montier-en-Der, Joachim of Fiore, the Spiritual Franciscans, Savonarola* (Mahwah, NJ, 1979), 142–8. A German translation and commentary is included in Riedl, *Joachim von Fiore*, 309–34.

obvious that all of Joachim's political and social ideas are deduced from his insight into things invisible:

1. *Processiones*, the transcendental sphere of divine reality. The paramount reality is the triune essence of the divinity, into which Joachim gained insight at the occasion of the Pentecostal vision of the psaltery. It is the transcendent sphere of the eternal processions (*processiones*) which determine the properties of the divine persons: a) the Father proceeds from no other person, but Son and Spirit proceed from him; b) the Son proceeds from the Father while the Spirit proceeds from him, and c) the Spirit proceeds from the Son and the Father.
2. *Missiones*, the historical sphere of divine self-revelation. As a result of Adam's fall, man lost his knowledge of his creator and God began a long process of re-education. The missions (*missiones*) that happen in the course of the revelatory process correspond to the processions inside the transcendent sphere: a) there is no mission of the Father, but the Father sends the Son and the Spirit; b) the Son is sent on his mission by the Father while he himself sends the Spirit, together with the Father, and c) the Spirit is sent by the Father and the Son.
3. *Littera* and *intellectus*, the sphere of human understanding. The missions find their expressions in the letter (*littera*) of the Bible. The more God reveals about himself the greater is the human understanding (*intellectus*) of the mysteries hidden in the text: a) the revelation of the Father manifests itself in the letter of the Old Testament; b) from the letter of the Old Testament proceeds the letter of the New Testament, revealing a deeper meaning of the Old Testament, and c) from the letter of the Old and the New Testament proceeds spiritual understanding, the most profound understanding of the revelatory text.
4. *Ordines*, the sphere of social order. The increasing knowledge about divine revelation manifests itself in the social structure of the people of God and its orders (*ordines*): a) knowledge of the Father manifests itself in the patriarchal order of Israel; b) knowledge of the Son lets the clerical order proceed from the lay people, and c) from the orders of the clerics and the laity proceeds the order of the monks.

Joachim's prophecies about the future of Christian society are obviously influenced by contemporary developments. On the one hand, the abbot stands in the tradition of the Gregorian reform movement and papal policy since the investiture controversy: the liberty of the church (*libertas ecclesiae*) was to be accomplished by depriving the laity of all control. On the other hand, Joachim observed the Cistercian movement as well as the manifold forms of monasticism which spread, with as yet unknown speed, across the West. Therefore, in two

respects Joachim goes beyond the goals of the Gregorian reformers. Firstly, the purification of the clergy is not enough; the church must become a monastic and spiritual church. Secondly, it is not sufficient to liberate the church from the hands of lay rulers; the liberty of the church will be complete only once worldly power no longer exists.

By interpreting the Bible and his own spiritual experiences, Joachim finally found an answer to the fundamental political question which occupies him in all of his main works: What must Christianity look like if it is perfectly ordered and differentiated (*si religio Christiana perfecte esset ordinata et distincta*)?⁶⁹

⁶⁹ Joachim of Fiore, *Concordia*, fol. 71rb.